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Toward a Feminist Ethic of War and Peace

Sarah Tobias

JEAN ELSHTAIN BEGINS her chapter by asserting that “there is no separate feminist tradition on war and peace.” According to Elshtain, feminist approaches to international relations theory are largely derivative, reflecting familiar themes from within the mainstream literature. Yet she finds enough in the “rough-and-ready feminist outlook” to merit an extended discussion of the relationship between feminism and issues of war and peace. Furthermore, although she notes that feminism is heterogeneous, Elshtain suggests that most feminist scholarship on war and peace falls into one of two polar categories, symbolized by either the bellicose Spartan Mother or the pacifist Beautiful Soul.

I will consider Elshtain’s claims in relation to contemporary feminist scholarship. Her account is problematic because she approaches feminist writings on war and peace primarily as an exercise in historical exegesis rather than as an exploration in international ethics. Although she occasionally alludes to conceptions of value, ends, and moral judgment, and to familiar paradigms in international ethics, Elshtain does not delve beneath the surface of feminist discourse to address the ethical positions elaborated in these writings. In particular, she fails to distinguish between normative and descriptive elements in the arguments she considers—both those of realism and natural law theory, on the one hand, and those of feminist theory, on the other. This conflation of norms and description effectively undermines the analytical power of the Spartan Mother/Beautiful Soul dichotomy. The complexity of feminist arguments about war and peace cannot adequately be captured by polar categories that are simultaneously amorphous and reductionist.

Many of the difficulties that beset Elshtain’s discussion stem from her insistence that “each articulated feminist position represents either an evolution within or a break-out from a previous historic discourse.” Spartan Motherhood, she suggests, is a variant of political realism, while Beautiful Souldom is a hybrid of the natural law and pacifist traditions. The prevailing paradigms in international ethics are not, however, the primary influences on feminist writings on war and peace. Rather, feminists who address these topics draw upon their own traditions of moral and political thought. Feminism is a political movement dedicated to ending the subordination

of women by challenging the existence and implications of gender distinction. In so doing, feminists have developed new understandings of domination and subordination, authority and resistance, violence and peace. Feminists' ontological and epistemological claims are drawn from women's experience, and they neither replicate nor simply refurbish familiar philosophical concepts. These claims have enabled feminists to develop alternative approaches to questions of reason, motivation, and moral obligation to those found in conventional discourses.

Some elaboration is necessary to clarify the character of ethics and to assess the impact of applying feminist ethics to international affairs. In this chapter, I define ethics broadly to include considerations of value, judgment, and the good life.¹ Thus ethics both incorporates and transcends a narrow focus on morality. Diverse references to ethics pervade most feminist texts, regardless of the political propensities of their authors. Radical feminists, like Andrea Dworkin, Mary Daly, and Susan Brownmiller, do not present these references systematically, and they must therefore be carefully extricated from the complex arguments in which they are embedded.² Other feminists, such as Nel Noddings, Virginia Held, and Joan Tronto, draw upon the empirical studies of the psychologist Carol Gilligan to develop systematic interpretations of the ethics of care.³ These feminists do not conceive of morality as consisting of abstract and universal standards; rather, they maintain that morality entails responsiveness to particular relationships in specific contexts. When the ethics of care is applied to international affairs, the result is an approach to war and peace that differs qualitatively from the principled rationalism of natural law theory and the self-interested consequentialism of political realism. Despite some serious and unresolved theoretical problems, the ethics of care therefore poses a fundamental challenge to the dominant perspectives on international ethics.

RADICAL FEMINISM

To reveal the flaws in Elshtain's argument, I will consider in turn the perspectives of radical and care-oriented feminists. Before assessing the radical feminist discussion of war and peace, however, it will be useful to recall Elshtain's characterization of feminist realism. She argues that this approach to international affairs derives from the prefeminist conception of Spartan Motherhood. The Spartan Mother's main concern is with the security of her family and country. Accordingly, reasons of state are sufficient to justify a military response to threats of violence or incursion. Clearly, Elshtain's account of Spartan Motherhood reflects political realism's preoccupation with self-interested justifications for using force. Although Elshtain does not address this preoccupation directly, her discussion of

feminist realism's Hobbesian character implies the importance of self-interest. Feminist realists, she suggests, see social life as an "undeclared but total war between men and women" and "advise women to 'fight dirty.'" For such feminists, "'anything goes' to achieve the overthrow of patriarchy." Although she stresses the similarities between feminist realism and political realism, Elshtain hints at one major difference between the two perspectives. Whereas political realists see peace as an unstable condition, constantly threatened by the security dilemma, feminist realists share the conviction that "naturally pacifistic" women will ultimately triumph and govern in peace. Thus Elshtain implies that essentialism anomalously undercuts the radical feminist adherence to realist premises.

A striking feature of Elshtain's treatment of feminism's "Machiavellian moment" is her reluctance to distinguish between the larger radical feminist tradition and radical feminist *realism*. The ensuing confusion between two quite different outlooks is compounded by her claim (in note 14) that the presumptions of feminist realism are widely shared. Although some of the earliest, most polemical works of radical feminist theory reflect a ruthless disregard for customary moral constraints, most radical feminist arguments only superficially resemble those of political realists.⁴ Radical feminists draw upon their own analyses of the politics of women's oppression to subvert conventional archetypes.

This is particularly evident in the radical feminist approach to war. Radical feminists dispute the realist definition of war as "organized violence carried out by political units against each other."⁵ Instead, they suggest that the global oppression of the gender class women by the gender class men is also a kind of war. In this war, men use physical and psychological violence to control women's labor and sexuality. Men thereby intimidate women into universal submission.

Since women are subject to varying intensities of violence, Andrea Dworkin and other radical feminists distinguish between war and what Dworkin calls "primary emergency."⁶ Dworkin describes three particularly horrific instances that illustrate this kind of extremity: the thousand years during which Chinese men bound and crippled Chinese women's feet, the mass burnings of women as witches by European and American men, and the raping of Bengali women by male soldiers. To these examples Mary Daly adds the ritualistic brutality of African "genital mutilation" and the abuse American women suffer at the hands of gynecologists and mental health professionals.⁷ By asserting that war is a global and gendered phenomenon rather than a state-centric one, radical feminists like Dworkin and Daly challenge the association between war and national interest that is central to realist thought. In so doing, radical feminists project a conception of international relations that is based on women's shared personal

and political experiences of oppression instead of on the diplomatic and military maneuvering of states.⁸

Radical feminists do not merely define war in broader terms than those acknowledged by realists. They also counter the realist claim that war “represents the abandonment of policy.”⁹ Indeed, radical feminists suggest that war is synonymous with patriarchy, that is, the consolidation of policy under “institutionalized male supremacy.”¹⁰ They therefore assert that the war of men against women entails both order and hierarchy. Clearly, the radical feminist analysis of war diverges fundamentally from the “Hobbesian social ontology” that Elshtain ascribes to radical feminism. According to Hobbes, the state of nature is inhabited by men who are equally prudent and rational, hopeful and powerful—and thus likely to compete for scarce resources on equal terms. War, for Hobbes, entails a kind of equality. Radical feminists insist that women are the *victims* of a violent war waged against them by men. War, for them, implies *inequality*. Women are coerced into modifying their hopes and expectations to fit the constraints of life in a male-dominated society.

Radical feminists posit an alternative to patriarchy that challenges the realist reluctance to countenance “any equation of peace with justice.”¹¹ Freedom and justice are central to the radical feminist vision of a postpatriarchal world. The radical feminist understanding of freedom, which resembles Berlin’s conception of positive liberty,¹² reflects a desire for “self-determination, self-enrichment, the freedom to live one’s own life, set one’s own goals, the freedom to rejoice in one’s own accomplishments.”¹³ At the same time, radical feminists distinguish between justice and social equality. Recognizing that the latter might be attainable without a fundamental transformation of patriarchal institutions, they maintain that this outcome can never be “a proper, or sufficient, or moral, or honorable final goal.”¹⁴ Justice requires the eradication of patriarchy in general and of culturally constructed gender roles in particular. As one radical feminist remarks:

We believe that the male world as it now exists is based on the corrupt notion of “maleness vs. femaleness,” that the oppression of women is based on this very notion and its attendant institutions. . . . We must eradicate the sexual division on which our society is based. Only then do men and women have a hope of living together as human beings.¹⁵

Given this emphasis on the eradication of sexual polarities, it is clear that not all radical feminists envisage a future tied to images of pacifistic womanhood ruling according to the dictates of their nature. Although some radical feminists do endorse a kind of pacifist essentialism, many of the most sophisticated theorists within this tradition argue instead that an-

drogyny is a crucial component of peace. That Elshtain does not comment on the importance of androgyny for radical feminists suggests that her characterization of their thought is selective and incomplete.

Radical feminists have little loyalty to the state because it functions as an instrument of patriarchal oppression. There are, however, divergent opinions within radical feminism about how best to resist patriarchy. Some radical feminists describe resistance primarily in psychological terms. According to Mary Daly, for example, it is important for women to destroy the "patriarchal Lie" by "burning/melting/vaporizing the constricting walls imposed upon the Self."¹⁶ For Daly, resisting patriarchy ultimately involves separatism. Susan Brownmiller, in contrast, argues that women can resist patriarchy in a variety of ways. Thus she argues that women should learn self-defense to protect themselves from attack. It is only within this context that she stresses the importance of learning to "fight dirty." Contrary to Elshtain's implication, Brownmiller never advocates a violent or militaristic strategy "to take over the extant power structure." Indeed, Brownmiller condemns "premeditated murder" and other violent crimes. She suggests instead that the best way for women to oppose patriarchy is through the criminal justice system.¹⁷

The most significant account of resistance from within the radical feminist canon is provided by Andrea Dworkin. Dworkin argues that patriarchy will ultimately be overthrown by a "revolutionary sisterhood." The sisterhood will refuse to perform domestic chores for men. It will also campaign for equal political rights and demand the integration of more women into the criminal justice system. To address the problem of rape, the sisterhood will campaign for new laws, refuse to "participate in the dating system which sets up every woman as a potential rape victim," "publicize unprosecuted cases of rape," and "make the identities of rapists known to other women."¹⁸ Clearly, the strategy that Dworkin advocates to overthrow patriarchy is a far cry from the admonition to "fight dirty" that Elshtain finds typical of feminist realists.

When Dworkin advises women to press for political change by challenging current law, and ultimately by renouncing all forms of male control, she insists upon the application of stringent ethical standards to conduct. These standards militate overwhelmingly against the "anything goes" approach that Elshtain ascribes to radical feminists. Thus Dworkin argues that the revolutionary sisterhood will be guided in its struggle against patriarchy by the "values which originate in sisterhood." These values dictate an absolute commitment to nonviolence. For women to "betray . . . the worth of human life," she argues, would be for them to "internalize . . . [male] values and . . . replicate [male] crimes."¹⁹

Dworkin's discussion of the ethics of resistance emphasizes the reductionism inherent in Elshtain's account. As we have seen, by suggesting that

“anything goes” when radical feminists contend with the enemy, Elshtain implies that radical feminists ignore moral constraints in conflict. Thus Elshtain plays on a variant of “vulgar” realism that is a recurrent motif in international relations theory. Yet in equating radical feminist arguments with realist ones, Elshtain not only distorts radical feminism but maligns the realist tradition as well. For political realists do not necessarily advocate an amoral approach to international affairs. More frequently, realism involves juggling the competing claims of morality and self-interest. Realists differ dramatically in determining when, precisely, moral constraints should be ignored. For some, it is only in extremity that self-interest requires abandoning moral constraints to secure the survival of the state and the community it embodies.²⁰ Indeed, from an ethical perspective, this state-centric consequentialism is perhaps the defining characteristic of political realism.

It is abundantly clear from Dworkin’s writings that she does not advocate a consequentialist approach to war and peace. By insisting on women’s absolute allegiance to nonviolent principles, Dworkin endorses an approach to resistance that is antithetical to realism. Since Elshtain fails to distinguish between the normative and descriptive elements of political realism and radical feminism, her account obscures the importance of deontological reasoning in the radical feminist canon.

Yet despite Dworkin’s deontological emphasis, her account is no closer to Elshtain’s description of the Beautiful Soul than it is to feminist realism. Dworkin rejects Elshtain’s claim that for the Beautiful Soul, “the condition of society is not ‘war’; it is injustice to be fought by nonviolent means.” Moreover, Dworkin’s stress upon androgyny is at odds with the Beautiful Soul’s desire “to translate . . . maternal imperatives into a public good.” Elshtain’s Spartan Mother/Beautiful Soul dichotomy is, in short, far too simplistic to capture the nuances of radical feminist thought.

THE ETHIC OF CARE

Although radical feminists contest many of the definitions that are central to realist accounts of war and peace, they neither challenge the distinction between deontological and consequentialist reasoning in international ethics, nor question the way in which political realists and natural lawyers interpret this distinction. I want to consider how a fully developed feminist ethic of war and peace would transcend the conventional construction of the deontological/consequentialist distinction.

The consequentialism advocated by realists is distinguished by its focus on self-interested justifications for using force. Yet the realist conception of morality is nevertheless a principled one. Realists acknowledge “the moral importance of impartial calculations” about various rules of war,

such as those concerning proportionality, even if they ultimately fail to abide by them.²¹ Indeed, Morgenthau insists that when statesmen act immorally to promote the national interest, their acts may still be judged by universal moral principles.²² Natural law theorists are, of course, even more insistent than realists that morality should be understood as a set of principles. The recognition by both realists and natural law theorists that moral principles are embedded in a complex ethical system, and that they are neither simple nor unambiguous, does not sever the close link between morality and principle that exists in these traditions.

Both realism and natural law theory have their antecedents in Western traditions of moral and political philosophy. Feminists have recently begun to argue that these traditions are gender-biased, reflecting the ontological and epistemological concerns of men. Some feminists have responded to this assertion by drawing directly from women's moral experience to construct an alternative approach to ethics: the ethics of care.

Among the commonalities shared by feminists working on the ethics of care is the propensity to define morality as a practice. Unlike Michael Oakeshott, for whom morality is a noninstrumental practice, "without any extrinsic purpose,"²³ these feminists argue that morality is a practice directed toward a concrete end: providing for the care of specific others in particular contexts. They differ from one another, however, in how they delineate the ethical aspects of care. Joan Tronto, for example, identifies four types of caring practice, each of which has an ethical component: attentiveness, responsibility, competence, and responsiveness. In contrast to Tronto, Nel Noddings distinguishes between natural caring, "that relation in which we respond as one—caring out of love or natural inclination," and ethical caring. The latter entails acting to protect another person or to promote his or her welfare in accordance with an ethical ideal: a "memory of our own best moments of caring and being cared for."²⁴ However feminists define the ethics of care, they understand it to be a way of sustaining the tenuous social ties that bind individuals to one another. Care-oriented feminists thus reiterate Carol Gilligan's claim that moral practice primarily entails a focus on "responsibility and relationships."²⁵

The feminist approach to the ethics of care, with its stress on benevolence, seems at first glance to reflect the natural law tradition's emphasis on *caritas*, *concordia*, and *societas*. Yet care-oriented feminists reject the natural lawyer's assertion that moral conduct is synonymous with "an unconditional adherence to the truth about what reason requires."²⁶ Since the contexts in which individuals need care are diverse and always changing, many care-oriented feminists eschew truth claims for an appreciation of the indeterminate character of moral obligations. They reject the tendency to equate reason with "abstract and hypothetical" logic, since this excludes women's experience of thought linked to the emotive and the concrete. Whereas some feminists argue that the connection between rationality

and morality should therefore be severed altogether, others attempt to construct alternative conceptions of rationality that link reason with emotion in a “contextual and narrative” mode.²⁷ By depicting morality as a practice in which reason and emotion are intertwined, feminists deflect many of the questions that theorists often pose to differentiate motive (spirit) and intention (aim).

The feminist preoccupation with an ethic of context results in an approach to judgment that differs procedurally from natural law theory and substantively from realism. In contrast to natural law theory, the ethics of care stipulates that it is not necessary to establish an action’s “practical reasonableness” before deeming it morally correct. The rectitude of an act is determined largely by its consequences. Whereas the philosophical forebears of realism, like Machiavelli, endorse a self-interested consequentialism, feminist advocates of the ethics of care stress that the relevant consequences are predominantly those that concern the impact of care-giving on particular others.²⁸ Unlike Hobbes, another realist forebear, feminists argue that moral practices cannot be codified into universal imperatives without misrepresenting their character. Thus Tronto notes that “care is distorted if we separate the principles of care—that care is necessary—from the particular practices of care in a given situation.”²⁹ Some feminists therefore discard the moral significance of principles altogether. In this spirit, Noddings asserts that “to care is to act not by fixed rule but by affection and regard.”³⁰ Even those feminists who acknowledge the need for some general principles stipulate that these must “be compatible with particular judgments based . . . on feelings of empathy and on caring concern rather than on rational calculation or abstract reasoning.”³¹

Given that the care-oriented approach to ethics differs substantively from approaches based on rational principles and procedural justice, it is not surprising that even the most problematic applications of the ethics of care to international affairs do not “reproduce . . . [the] assumptions that structure the historic discourses of realism and just war.”³² Rather, care-oriented feminism raises important questions about the paradigms currently used to analyze issues of war and peace. Many of these questions are considered in the work of Sara Ruddick. Although other feminists have attempted to apply the ethics of care to international affairs, Ruddick contributes the first sustained feminist discussion of international ethics. Ruddick’s argument is therefore indicative of how feminists might proceed to develop their own ethics of war and peace.

Ruddick’s approach to the ethics of war and peace is derived from the practice of mothering. According to Ruddick, “men can be mothers.” Yet because motherhood has generally been the responsibility of women, and as “in most cultures the womanly and the maternal are conceptually and politically linked,” the ethical outlook derived from maternal practice is strongly associated with gender.³³ Maternal practice involves the

formation of strong bonds between mother and child. The relationship that develops between them challenges the liberal conception of autonomous man, whose competitive impulses are constrained by rules and rights. Rather, mother and child are interdependent, mutually responsive, and motivated by the responsibility of care. The ties that connect a mother and her child inspire and are reflected in a particular type of thinking. Ruddick argues that “maternal thinking” involves a style of judgment and a set of values and ends that differ significantly from “dominant public ones.”³⁴ That is to say, maternal thinking constitutes a unique system of feminist ethics.

A central characteristic of maternal ethics is that it defines the right in terms of the good. Maternal conduct is virtuous to the extent that it furthers the preservation, growth, and social acceptability of a child. A mother struggles to achieve the virtues of humility (“a metaphysical attitude one takes toward a world beyond one’s control”) and of clear-sighted cheerfulness (“a matter-of-fact willingness . . . to welcome life despite its conditions”).³⁵ Most importantly, a mother strives to cultivate the “capacity” and “virtue” of attentive love. Such love requires the coincidence of empathetic attention and love in a way that serves to “keep . . . [a child] safe and help her grow.” A mother whose thought is guided by attentive love will ask her child the question, “What are you going through?” and listen carefully to the response. Yet a mother’s empathy should never be so all-consuming that it confuses the identities of mother and child. Attentive love functions most appropriately when a “mother really looks at her child” and “tries to see him accurately rather than herself in him.”³⁶

Attentive love encourages mothers to make ethical judgments in a “concrete” fashion. Ruddick argues that because mothers respond to particular children, their judgments are nuanced and context-bound. Thus she observes that “concreteness requires inventing alternatives even when there seem to be none, looking closely at what is happening, [and] . . . asking hard questions.” Ruddick contrasts concreteness with the tendency to think abstractly and to simplify the complexities of moral life into “dichotomous choices.”³⁷ She claims that abstract rules can even encourage war because, so often, those who fight do so out of loyalty to an abstract cause. Ruddick is particularly hostile to just war theory because its abstractions invite soldiers and civilians “to turn away from the details of suffering, to see instead the just causes and conventional rules of war.”³⁸ By contrast, Ruddick suggests that there will be “greater safety, pleasure, and justice in a world where the values of care are dominant.”³⁹ Ruddick’s own approach to international ethics is derived from maternal thinking and is constructed as a concrete alternative to both just war theory and political realism.

Ruddick argues that because mothers experience conflict with children, families, and external authorities as part of their daily lives, resistance is a

part of maternal practice. Concomitantly, mothers require an ability to restore peaceful relationships with those whom they care about. Ruddick suggests that maternal responses to conflict could easily be extended to international politics. "Nonviolent peacemaking," her approach to international affairs, is governed by four ideals: "renunciation, resistance, reconciliation, and peacekeeping." The first of these, the "renunciation of violent strategies and weapons," is particularly important for Ruddick's attempt to apply maternal thinking to global politics. She notes that because mothers are generally weaponless, they often try to achieve their goals by adopting strategies like "prayer, persuasion, appeasement, self-suffering, negotiation, bribery, invocation of authority, ridicule, and many other sorts of psychological manipulation." Since most of these tactics can on occasion be injurious, Ruddick suggests that mothers make special efforts "to distinguish permissible hurt from damaging harm."⁴⁰ Nonviolent peacemaking therefore requires an ability to evaluate thoroughly the specific circumstances that might warrant conflict, and to appreciate that different ways of fighting will be appropriate in different struggles.

In an early essay, Ruddick argues that maternal thinking, like pacifism, requires "the renunciation of violence even if—and where—violence seems the only means to achieve a desired end."⁴¹ Although she retains a preference for nonviolent action, her later writings modify the absolutism of her earlier stance. In these writings she acknowledges that sometimes, in an international context, it will be necessary to use force. Thus she asserts that "it is unnecessary and divisive to require of all peacemakers an absolute commitment not to kill."⁴² Nevertheless, like mothers, those committed to peacemaking will avoid fighting if they can and, if they cannot, will strive to limit all battles. When the fighting is over, peacemakers publicize criminal acts, holding those who have committed them accountable. Ultimately, however, a peacemaker will endeavor to forgive her enemies. She will therefore act in the recognition that her relationship with her neighbors must continue long after the fighting is over.

There are many problems with Ruddick's approach to war and peace. Her attempt to define a care-oriented international ethic is incomplete because she never develops a comprehensive account of motivation, moral judgment, or obligation in international affairs. Moreover, Ruddick fails to explain why mothering is the most appropriate practice from which to develop an international ethic of care. This is especially important since a mother's concern for her own children can prevent her from attending to the needs of others. If maternal imperatives are transplanted into an international context, the result is potentially a very parochial ethic. Guided by the ethics of care, governments might seek to foster the preservation and growth of the states with which they are most closely linked while ignoring those that are geographically or culturally distant. Even more problemati-

cally, Ruddick sometimes uses the mother-child relationship as an analogy for the ideal conduct of states in the international system, thereby raising awkward questions about the relationship between power and order. Whereas a mother is often very powerful compared to a child—she can exert her will to direct and discipline her offspring—there is no disciplinary mother figure in the international system, nor is there any other effective form of common government. Ruddick's mother-child analogy therefore seems fundamentally at odds with a decentralized international system in which order cannot be imposed from above.

Despite the difficulties in Ruddick's account, her approach suggests that a fully developed feminist ethic of war and peace would be significantly different from both natural law theory and political realism. Since Ruddick shuns any uniform and abstract commitment to moral principles, and eschews all Kantian-style claims of duty, she clearly rejects the principle-oriented approach of natural law theory. Her emphasis on contextual judgment therefore permits a more flexible approach to international conduct than is permitted by natural law. Yet although Ruddick is a consequentialist, she is not a realist. Many realists argue that the rules of war should be observed when useful, but ignored when they conflict with reasons of state. Implicit in this position is the assumption that when statesmen reject the rules of war, they also reject moral claims. By denying the moral force of principles and endorsing a radically contextualized morality, Ruddick articulates a conception of international ethics that defies classification in conventional terms, and that owes more to Gilligan than to Aquinas, Suarez, Machiavelli, and Hobbes.

Given that Ruddick's approach to the ethics of war and peace differs from realism and natural law theory, it is not surprising that it also eludes the confines of Elshtain's Spartan Mother/Beautiful Soul dichotomy. Elshtain describes Ruddick's account of war and peace as an example of Beautiful Souldom. According to Elshtain, the Beautiful Soul acquires her moral convictions from the natural law and Christian pacifist traditions and therefore counsels "a nigh-absolute interdiction on female violence." Yet, as we have seen, Ruddick's peacemaker is neither a pacifist nor a deontologist. If the ethical aspects of Elshtain's categories are defining, then Elshtain misclassifies Ruddick's work.

CONCLUSION

Much contemporary feminist theory has sought to challenge inappropriate dichotomies in political philosophy. Feminists have addressed a series of distinctions, such as those between man and woman, public and private, and nature and culture, in an attempt to reveal their biased and exclusionary character. I have tried in this chapter to show how feminist approaches to the ethics of war and peace challenge the dominant dichotomies of in-

ternational ethics. Both radical feminism and the ethics of care differ from the self-interested consequentialism of political realism and the dutiful adherence to rational principle so central to natural law. Elshtain is therefore mistaken in claiming that feminism reproduces the “prototypical characters and arguments” of realism and natural law theory. Feminists subvert rather than reiterate these arguments and themes.

Since the application of feminist ethics to international affairs is a relatively recent phenomenon, many issues remain to be resolved. Feminists have yet to engage in many of the debates that concern international ethicists. Those who adopt a care-based approach to ethics need to address the problem that care in particular relationships provides little guidance on how to treat persons or communities outside those relationships. Furthermore, an emphasis on contextual morality threatens to reduce feminist ethics to state-centrism, and to ignore the international aspects of women's subordination. Finally, going beyond issues of war and peace, feminists have barely begun to address questions of global distributive justice. As we have seen, even the nascent feminist discussion of the ethics of war and peace challenges and subverts conventional analyses. A comprehensive feminist approach to these and other issues could contribute significantly to the ongoing discourse in international ethics.

NOTES

1. For a similar definition of ethics, see Elizabeth Frazer, Jennifer Hornsby, and Sabina Lovibond, eds., *Ethics: A Feminist Reader* (Oxford: Blackwell, 1992), 1–3.

2. Some lesbian feminists discuss ethics systematically. Alongside their own arguments, they sometimes develop particular radical feminist ideas specifically for application in the lesbian community. See Sarah Lucia Hoagland, *Lesbian Ethics* (Palo Alto, CA: Institute of Lesbian Studies, 1988).

3. Carol Gilligan, *In a Different Voice* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1982).

4. For an example of a kind of radical feminist amorality, see Valerie Solanis, “Excerpts from the SCUM (Society for Cutting Up Men) Manifesto,” in Robin Morgan, ed., *Sisterhood Is Powerful* (New York: Random House, 1970).

5. David Mapel, Chapter 3 above.

6. Andrea Dworkin, *Woman Hating* (New York: Plume Books, 1974), 23–24.

7. Mary Daly, *Gyn/Ecology* (Boston: Beacon Press, 1978).

8. This perspective is also adopted by scholars who are trying to develop a feminist approach to the empirical study of international relations. See, for example, Cynthia Enloe, *Bananas, Beaches, and Bases: Making Feminist Sense of International Politics* (Berkeley and Los Angeles: University of California Press, 1989).

9. Mapel, Chapter 3 above.

10. Marilyn French, *The War against Women* (New York: Ballantine Books, 1992), 16.

11. Mapel, Chapter 3 above, under “War and Peace.”

12. Isaiah Berlin, *Four Essays on Liberty* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1969), 118–72.
13. Chicago Women's Liberation, "Statement by Chicago Women's Liberation" in Morgan, *Sisterhood Is Powerful*, 531.
14. Dworkin, *Our Blood* (London: The Women's Press, 1982), 11.
15. Bonnie Kreps, "Radical Feminism 1'," in Anne Koedt, Ellen Levine, and Anita Rapone, eds., *Radical Feminism* (New York: Quadrangle Books, 1973), 239.
16. Daly, *Gyn/Ecology*, 20, 380.
17. Susan Brownmiller, *Against Our Will: Men, Women and Rape* (New York: Bantam Books, 1975), 453, 436, 426. Elshtain bases her characterization of the separatist strand of feminist "realism" in part on Brownmiller's book.
18. Dworkin, *Our Blood*, 20, 19, 43–44.
19. Dworkin, *Our Blood*, 65, 72, 65, 48.
20. This is the position taken by Michael Walzer in *Just and Unjust Wars* (New York: Basic Books, 1977).
21. Mapel, Chapter 3 above.
22. Hans J. Morgenthau, *Politics among Nations*, brief ed. rev. by Kenneth W. Thompson (New York: McGraw-Hill, 1993), 12.
23. Michael Oakeshott, *On Human Conduct* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1975), 62.
24. Nel Noddings, *Caring* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1984), 5, 79.
25. Gilligan, *In a Different Voice*, 19.
26. John Finnis, Chapter 1 above.
27. Sara Ruddick, "Remarks on the Sexual Politics of Reason," in Eva Feder Kittay and Diane T. Meyers, eds., *Women and Moral Theory* (Savage, MD: Rowman and Littlefield, 1987), 240.
28. It is important to note, however, that many feminists who advocate an ethic of care challenge the traditional dichotomy between egoism and altruism by arguing that the self is socially constituted rather than "antedecedently individuated." As Marilyn Friedman writes: "If the self is inherently social, then a concern for other persons is fundamental to the self and is not reducible to a mere variety of self-concern. Indeed, the conception of the social self tends somewhat to blur the distinction between self and other. If my relationship to someone or to some group is internal to who I am, then she or they are somehow a part of me. . . . I [therefore] show a moral attitude that is neither egoism nor self-denying altruism." See Marilyn Friedman, *What Are Friends For?* (Ithaca, NY: Cornell University Press, 1993), 68–69.
29. Joan C. Tronto, *Moral Boundaries* (New York and London: Routledge, Chapman, and Hall, 1993), 153.
30. Noddings, *Caring*, 24.
31. Virginia Held, *Feminist Morality* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1993), 35.
32. Jean Elshtain, Chapter 11 above. The feminist conception of the self, together with the feminist rejection of conventional understandings of reason and justice, differentiate the ethics of care from other contextual theories. The ethics of care does not replicate Christian "situation ethics," for example. Although they

regard the obligation to care as paramount, situation ethicists also assert that love is synonymous with justice and accept the natural lawyer's conviction that reason is "the instrument of moral judgment." See Joseph Fletcher, *Situation Ethics* (Philadelphia: Westminster Press, 1966), 26. Nor is the ethics of care a kind of utilitarianism. For ethics based upon the "principle of utility," whether defined in terms of welfare, the greatest happiness, or satisfaction, stands in stark contrast to the ethics of care's rejection of formulaic responses. Moreover, adherents of the ethics of care would probably endorse Rawls's concern that utilitarianism fails to "take seriously the distinction between persons" (John Rawls, *A Theory of Justice* [Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1971], 27). They would therefore criticize an approach to ethics in which the good of the majority always prevails over the good of the few as one in which particular relationships are depreciated.

33. Sara Ruddick, *Maternal Thinking* (New York: Ballantine Books, 1989), 41.

34. Sara Ruddick, "Maternal Thinking," in Joyce Trebilcot, ed., *Mothering* (Totowa, NJ: Rowman and Allanheld, 1983), 214.

35. Ruddick, "Maternal Thinking," 217–18.

36. Ruddick, *Maternal Thinking*, 119, 123, 121.

37. Ruddick, *Maternal Thinking*, 95.

38. Ruddick, "Preservative Love and Military Destruction: Some Reflections on Mothering and Peace," in Trebilcot, *Mothering*, 250.

39. Ruddick, *Maternal Thinking*, 135–36.

40. Ruddick, *Maternal Thinking*, 161, 165–66, 168.

41. Ruddick, "Preservative Love," 245.

42. Ruddick, *Maternal Thinking*, 138.

